

INDIA PICTURE

You can tell a lot about a musician by the instrument they choose to play, and that's especially true for Trilok Gurtu. The 71-year-old percussionist and composer has assembled a truly unique "floor kit" consisting of a tabla, drums, gongs, a djembe, ghungroo, cowbells and a water-filled bucket, which reflects the range of his stylistic influences. Much like his kit, Gurtu's music transcends genre and tradition—American jazz, Indian classical, African rhythm. This vision, of music without any barriers, has been his guide over a five-decade career as one of the most innovative musicians of our time.

"Music is one, God is one, that's what my guru [Ranjit Maharaj] told me," he says when we meet for coffee near his family home in Mumbai. The Germany-based musician is in town ahead of two shows, in Mumbai (on February 9) and New Delhi (on February 11) with Israeli classical orchestra Castle in Time.

Gurtu comes from a family with a strong musical heritage. His grandfather was a musicologist and sitar player. His mother, Shobha Gurtu, was a singer and popularly known as the "Thumri Queen". Unsurprisingly, he caught the music bug early, picking up the tabla at the age of five. At 11, he started training formally under Manikrao Popatkar from the Benares gharana, and would go on to learn from a series of notable masters, including tabla exponents: Ahmed Jan Thirakwa Khan and Pandit Suresh Talwalkar, and dholak player Abdul Karim Khan.

Even at a young age, Gurtu had no interest in being siloed within the Indian classical tradition. At home, he would also listen to folk music such as the Maharashtrian lavani and natya sangeet. His elder brother, Ravi, a much sought-after Bollywood percussionist in the 1970s, introduced him to the bongo and a range of other percussion instruments from around the world. When he was 18, he began playing drums for a band called Waterfront, playing jazz and rock compositions at discotheques and clubs. Waterfront found few takers in India, so the band embarked on a European

MUSIC

TUNES FOR A NEW INDIA

Coke Studio is back in India after eight years, and this time, the focus is on young music

In a span of two weeks, beloved fusion music series Coke Studio has announced two different chapters in India, and it turns out they will run independent of each other. On January 23, Coke Studio Tamil was announced as the platform's first foray into a language-specific edition, and now, there's Coke Studio Bharat, launched on February 7 with its first song.

After an eight-year gap since season four, there are a lot of expectations from the platform. They've got a diverse range of artistes behind the 10 songs for Coke Studio Bharat. Curated by singer-songwriter Ankur Tewari, the show also has sound engineer and producer K.J. Singh guiding the process with lyricist Kausar Munir (known most recently for writing the songs of the 2022 film *Gehraiyaan*).

On paper, these artistes represent the "new India" that Coke Studio Bharat wants to showcase, balancing the worlds



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